

Circle Internet Group (CRCL): Key takeaways from management meetings

On June 30th, we hosted meetings with CRCL's: 1) Co-founder, Chief Executive Officer and Chairman, Jeremy Allaire; and 2) Chief Financial Officer, Jeremy Fox-Green. Further detail within.

Management remain constructive on stablecoin adoption, citing growing adoption across both the digital asset ecosystem, and, increasingly, across a variety of areas within traditional finance, and highlighting recent growth in stablecoin volumes and market cap, vs. a weaker softer crypto market. The company highlighted broadening adoption across: 1) digital assets, driven by partnerships with scaled or fast-growing platforms (e.g., Hyperliquid); 2) cross-border payments and treasury management; 3) consumer commerce, with uptake and payments acceptance among leading payments companies, and, separately, the rise of stablecoin-linked credit cards; 4) capital markets, in which institutions are increasingly evaluating or adopting stablecoin as a settlement currency or as collateral, and facilitated by ongoing US regulatory reform; and 5) emerging agentic commerce use cases, with USDC representing ~99% of stablecoin payments on the dominant agentic commerce protocol, x402. Management also see upside from continued growth of tokenized real world assets (RWAs), for which stablecoin remains the natural settlement currency.

In terms of the competitive landscape, the company views stablecoins as structurally advantaged, relative to other forms of tokenized money, given greater interoperability and liquidity, by virtue of being a public and open internet financial system. It believes that USDC remain uniquely positioned to grow within the stablecoin ecosystem. Management noted that USDC is differentiated in its: 1) broad distribution and platform ecosystem, amplified by continuing to add partnerships that drive liquidity supernovas; 2) deep global liquidity across products and markets; and 3) differentiated infrastructure, in terms of robust transparency and global regulation. Further, the company noted that the cold start problem (including issues, such as a lack of network effects) likely limits the success of new stablecoins, vs. USDC, and that tokenized deposits have shortcomings, relative to stablecoins, in terms of more limited interoperability, as well the fact that they have bank credit risk, whereas stablecoins are fully reserved, without credit risk.

The company highlighted a strategic focus on adding additional partnerships, as well as building and expanding three key infrastructure offerings, which it believes can be combined with USDC to form a comprehensive on-chain financial

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stack: 1) the ARC Layer 1 blockchain, which CRCL views as a comprehensive financial operating system designed to enhance liquidity and interoperability appealing to traditional finance institutions; 2) the Circle Payments Network (CPN) cross-border payments product, which enables faster, more efficient cross-border payments through blockchain settlement; and 3) CRCL's agentic stack, in which investments are targeted at maintaining CRCL's dominant share in AI-related economic activities. In addition, management highlighted that they remain committed to expanding USDC distribution through partnerships, targeting platforms with strong, rapidly scaling liquidity that reinforce USDC's existing network effects. They will continue to share economics with this type of partner.

Management view the proposed market structure bill as a regulatory unlock, rather than a risk to the growth or economics of USDC. They believe that, as currently drafted, the CLARITY Act market structure bill would continue to allow issuers to incentivize distribution through revenue sharing, while establishing a clearer regulatory framework that could accelerate broader digital asset, and thus stablecoin, adoption. In terms of rewards, the company believes that, by permitting usage-based, rather than passive, yield-liked incentives, the bill would encourage transactional activity using stablecoins, rather than idle balance accumulation, which would more directly support adoption.

Additional key takeaways:

- **Stablecoin/USDC adoption:** Management continue to see proliferation of stablecoin use cases across both crypto and decentralized finance, and, increasingly, in traditional finance, as evidenced by the recent decoupling of stablecoin growth from declining crypto volumes and prices. Specifically, the company highlighted growing USDC adoption across:
 - **Cross-border payments and treasury management:** Management highlighted that stablecoins are increasingly being used in bilateral cross-border payment flows, driven by the instant settlement and minimal transaction cost of stablecoins. They allow for more efficient treasury operations to achieve more efficient global settlement and money movements across card networks and other payments companies. Further, the company noted digital dollarization, or broad based organic growth in global dollar-backed stablecoin demand as a substitute for currencies or domestic banking, as a significant structural tailwind to adoption. They are seeing emerging markets adopt USDC, as well as transactions between developed and emerging markets.
 - **Consumer commerce:** While nascent, CRCL noted growing consumer commerce usage of stablecoins, namely: 1) the rise of stablecoin-linked credit cards, through which users can hold and spend stablecoins; and 2) emerging stablecoin payment acceptance of USDC on major commerce platforms, e.g., Stripe and Shopify. When customers check out, they can choose to pay for purchases with USDC.
 - **Agentic commerce:** Management noted that AI agents have begun to undertake economic activity, namely in fraction-of-a-cent transactions through machine-native protocols, on which stablecoin's atomic settlement

and minimal transaction costs are uniquely suitable. Further, the company pointed to its dominant share within agentic commerce, with USDC accounting for ~99% of all transactions on x402, the leading agentic payment protocol.

- **Capital market:** The company highlighted that stablecoins are beginning to see proliferation within traditional financial markets as a form of collateral, and as a settlement currency. The company noted increasing use of USDC in derivatives, tokenized asset markets, and broader financial market infrastructure. Further, they view the recent CFTC permission of Futures Commission Merchants (FCMs) to treat select stablecoins as readily marketable collateral as an important catalyst that could enable adoption over time. Finally, management noted that continued tokenization of real world assets likely supports further adoption, as stablecoins represent the natural on-chain cash leg for transacting and settlement.
- **Strategic focus areas:** Management remained focused on expanding its infrastructure offerings, as CRCL continues to transition into an internet financial platform. They highlighted three key near-term product focus areas: 1) Arc, CRCL's proprietary L1 blockchain, which they view as a comprehensive financial operating system, designed to improve liquidity and interoperability; 2) Circle Payments Network (CPN), CRCL's cross-border payments product, which has continued to see strong and growing institutional adoption; and 3) CRCL's agentic products, in which the company is investing to enable developers and enterprises to build and deploy AI agents. Management noted that these three products are intrinsically connected to the broader Circle ecosystem, and reinforce the company's utility network effects. In addition, management emphasized that partnerships remain central to CRCL's distribution strategy, and they will continue to target partners with large, established liquidity, as well as attractive growth profiles. As scaling the network remains key to its strategy, CRCL is willing to strategically share issuance economics for key new partnerships that expand distribution.
- **Competitive backdrop:** The company highlighted that stablecoins generally, and USDC in particular, are network effect businesses, and they are networks. The network is the public software infrastructure on the internet – anyone can connect to this stablecoin network, across individuals, businesses, or developers. Management view stablecoins as the form of tokenized cash with the most utility, and believe USDC is best-positioned offering within stablecoins, given its best-in-class interoperability, its best-in-class liquidity, and the strength of its infrastructure, in terms of transparency and significant global regulation. Further detail:
 - **Stablecoin vs. tokenized deposits:** Management view stablecoins as structurally advantaged, relative to tokenized deposits. Specifically, the company noted that stablecoins: 1) inherently offer greater liquidity and interoperability, by virtue of being public and open, whereas tokenized deposits are more likely to remain confined within individual bank or consortium ecosystems, which is the way banks have been built until now; and 2) represent fully reserved bearer digital cash, rather than tokenized bank liabilities that have bank credit risk.

- **New stablecoin competitors:** The company expects to see additional new stablecoin competition, but noted that the cold start problem likely limits the success of these new stablecoins. Specifically, management stated that these new stablecoins lack network effects that CRCL has built over more than a decade.
- **Competitive advantages of USDC:** The company believes USDC remains differentiated vs. other stablecoins, as evidenced by its dominant ~80% stablecoin transaction volume share in 1Q26. The company highlighted several competitive advantages of USDC, including: 1) the breadth of its distribution and platform ecosystem, which continues to strengthen through additional partnerships; 2) deep global liquidity across exchanges, OTC markets, payments and collateral markets, reinforcing network effects and utility; and 3) a differentiated regulatory infrastructure spanning multiple jurisdictions, which management believe will encourage institutional adoption.
- **Increasing stablecoin participation by tradfi:** The company views increasing participation from traditional financial institutions in the stablecoin ecosystem as an opportunity rather than a competitive threat, arguing that broader issuer participation should accelerate institutional adoption and ecosystem growth.
- **International expansion:** Management maintained a constructive view on international expansion opportunities for USDC, highlighting growing demand for regulated digital dollars outside of the United States, particularly for cross-border payments and treasury use cases. The company believes international adoption should be supported by: 1) increasing institutional demand for fast, low-cost cross-border payments; 2) ongoing stablecoin regulation globally; and 3) partnerships with regional financial institutions, payment providers, and digital asset platforms that should broaden local stablecoin distribution.
- **Regulatory backdrop:** The company continues to view the CLARITY Act market structure bill as a USDC growth tailwind, rather than a constraint on its economics and distribution. Management highlighted that, as written, CLARITY: 1) would maintain issuers' ability to enter into revenue sharing arrangements for distribution, which support CRCL's ability to continue to add partners; 2) could unlock meaningful incremental institutional crypto adoption, leading to greater overall stablecoin usage; and 3) promotes usage-based, instead of passive, yield-equivalent rewards. In the company's view, this incentivization encourages greater active use of stablecoin, rather than idle balance accumulation, which is good for overall adoption of the product.

Rating: We are Neutral-rated on CRCL. Our 12-month price target of \$96 is based on 35.0x Q5-Q8 P/E.

Risks: Downside risks: Ecosystem growth slows; as a result of a weaker crypto market backdrop; Market share gains from USDT not continuing; Coinbase de-emphasizes USDC; and competition from other stable coins. Upside risks: favorable crypto regulation; further increases in crypto market cap; acceleration in market share gains from USDT; higher for longer rates benefiting reserve income.

CRCL	12m Price Target: \$96.00	Price: \$64.62	Upside: 48.6%
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Neutral		GS Forecast			
Market cap: \$17.5bn 3m ADTV: \$1.4bn United States Americas Banks and Advisors M&A Rank: 3	Revenue (\$ mn)	12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
	EPS (\$)	1.33	1.34	2.46	3.67
	P/E (X)	101.4	48.4	26.3	17.6
	P/B (X)	4.6	4.2	3.7	3.3
	ROA (%)	0.6	0.4	0.5	0.5
	ROE (%)	18.8	10.1	16.5	21.8
	Dividend yield (%)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
		3/26	6/26E	9/26E	12/26E
	EPS (\$)	0.32	0.30	0.32	0.39

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 2 Jul 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

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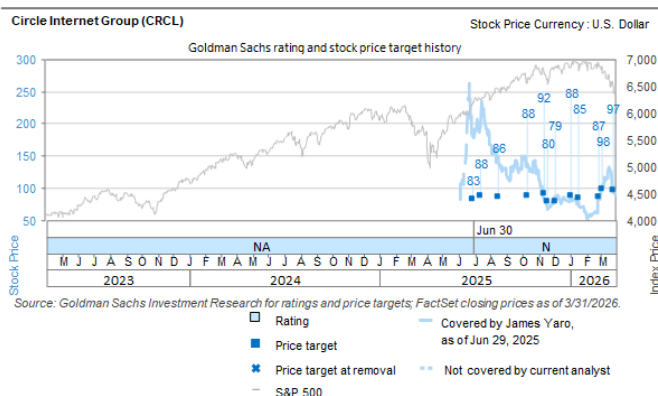
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Target price history table(s)

Circle Internet Group (CRCL)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
02-Jul-26	96.00	64.62
04-Jun-26	111.00	90.54
12-May-26	112.00	123.65
05-May-26	107.00	114.19
08-Apr-26	99.00	94.44
26-Mar-26	97.00	98.27
05-Mar-26	98.00	105.74
26-Feb-26	87.00	87.21
20-Jan-26	85.00	72.70
05-Jan-26	88.00	84.80
04-Dec-25	79.00	87.46
20-Nov-25	80.00	66.93
13-Nov-25	92.00	82.34
14-Oct-25	88.00	134.46
18-Aug-25	86.00	141.58
15-Jul-25	88.00	195.33
30-Jun-25	83.00	181.29

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